Queen Mary
University of London

Participant Information Sheet

Study title

A Comparative Study of Adults' Attitudes Towards Psychotherapy and Coaching

Version number and date

Version 0.4, 15 Mar 2026

Researcher's name

Nicholas (Nick) Hatter

Supervisor: Dr Joanne Wilson

Queen Mary Ethics of Research Committee reference number:

QME26.1924

Invitation paragraph

You are being invited to participate in a research study on coaching and psychotherapy. Before you decide whether you wish to participate in this study, it is important for you to understand **why** the research is being done and **what** it will involve. Please take time to read the following information **carefully** and discuss it with others if you wish.

What is the purpose of the study and what would taking part involve?

The purpose of the study is to examine public perceptions of coaching and psychotherapy. This study is for **a master's dissertation** in MSc in Mental Health: Psychological Therapies at the Centre for Psychiatry & Mental Health at Queen Mary University London.

By taking part in the study, you consent to allow the Researcher and Queen Mary University London to use a **fully anonymised version** of the data you provide in this survey in research outputs. No one outside of the research team will be able to identify your responses, thus helping preserve anonymity and confidentiality.

Your name and identity **will not be included** in the study, and will be kept **private and confidential**. Only your **anonymised** survey data will be included, analysed and published from the study.

The study is expected to be concluded by **30th June 2026**.

Why am I being invited?

You are being invited because you may meet the demographic requirements for this study:

- At least 18 years old
- Male or female gender
- Located in the United Kingdom
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Do I have to take part?

It is **entirely up to you to decide** whether or not to take part in this research. If you choose to withdraw from the study, you can do so,please contact the primary researcher, Nicholas Hatter, by contacting him via Prolific's internal messaging system and please state 'Study Withdrawal' and provide your Prolific ID. To see how to do this, please see:

https://participant-help.prolific.com/en/articles/445028-how-can-i-contact-a-researcher

You can withdraw without providing a reason.

In the event of withdrawal, your survey data provided will be excluded from the study and deleted, provided that you withdraw **within 30 days** of submitting the survey. After 30 days, your data will be fully anonymised and retained as part of our research data.

Note that legitimate participation must be verified first before you can be paid the full incentive (as advertised on Prolific) for taking part. If you are disqualified from the study for any reason, a small incentive of £0.10 will be paid, provided that you click the Prolific URL provided on the disqualification screen to prove you have completed the survey.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

Partaking in the study may help participants become more self-aware of their own attitudes or internal barriers towards seeking psychological help. Furthermore, at a wider societal level, the study addresses a research gap regarding public attitudes towards psychotherapy and coaching. This study may also:

- Inform future public mental health campaigns aimed at reducing stigma around psychotherapy and other psychological interventions.

- Help policymakers, professional bodies and service planners understand how coaching is perceived relative to psychotherapy, which may be relevant for guidance on professional standards, regulation and public information.

- Contribute to the academic evidence base on help-seeking attitudes and self-stigma, providing a foundation for further research into how to reduce barriers to accessing appropriate psychological support.

Given the increase in members of the public seeking coaching, this study may help to provide the public with some insight as to why some individuals seek out coaching rather than psychotherapy.

What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?

If there are any data breaches, this could have potential negative reputational consequences if someone sees that you have a high self-stigma score or have perhaps previously engaged with coaching or psychotherapy services. Additionally, if you choose to share your income level, and there is a data breach, this could have reputational, financial and/or legal consequences for you. To mitigate this risk, participant identities will be kept **strictly private and confidential and will be fully anonymised (after the 30-day withdrawal period)** and will not be disclosed in any research outputs or to any researchers or supervisors.

If you become seriously distressed at any point during or after the study, contact NHS **111** or consult your GP, who can also provide out-of-hours care. If you are struggling to keep yourself safe, please call **999** or go to your nearest A&E. You can also call the Samaritans 24/7 365 days a year on **116 123** in the UK.

Expenses and payments

There are no expenses to take part as there is no travel required. The primary researcher will be responsible for approving the associated Prolific submission with this study (assuming you have taken part legitimately and answered all mandatory questions), after which, Prolific (Prolific Academic Ltd.). are solely and fully responsible for payments for taking part, and not the researchers nor Queen Mary University of London. We will only reimburse you to take part in the study **once**, and you may only take part in the study **once**.

Any attempts to fraudulently obtain multiple incentives (such as but not limited to submitting the survey multiple times, or attempting to bypass CAPTCHAs) may result in you being disqualified from the study (and not receiving an incentive) and being reported to Prolific for fraudulent behaviour.

What information about me will you be collecting?

This survey will collect data about attitudes towards coaching/psychotherapy. Demographic data will also be collected including age, gender, race, religion, and income level.. Additionally, you may however choose to opt out of providing your **race**, **religion,** and/or **income level**, as these are **optional** questions. However, all other questions are **mandatory** (unless otherwise specified), and you must complete them; otherwise, the Prolific Submission will be rejected, and you will **not** receive the incentive for taking part in this survey.

How will my data be stored and who will have access to it?

There will be a **pseudonymised version** stored on JISC (jisc.ac.uk) in a **secure encrypted** format initially, which contains your **Prolific ID**. This will only be accessible by the primary researcher and the research supervisor, and this version will be **deleted** once the 30-day withdrawal period lapses. **A fully anonymised version** of your survey data will be retained and accessible by other researchers upon publication of the research study. This means that your email address will be replaced with a participant identifier such as “Participant 1”, thus preserving **privacy, confidentiality, and therefore not revealing your identity.** At no point will anyone (except the primary researcher and research supervisor) have access to your Prolific ID.

When and how will my data be destroyed?

The original data containing your Prolific ID will be destroyed after the 30-day withdrawal period has lapsed. The **anonymised research data** will **not** be destroyed however, unless you have withdrawn from the study **within 30 days** of submitting the survey.

How will my data be used and shared?

This data will be accessible by others (including other researchers), but it will remain **fully anonymised**.

The survey data you provide via the survey will be statistically analysed to test one or more scientific hypotheses around coaching and psychotherapy, and the **fully anonymised version** of such data will be included in the researcher's master's dissertation.

The **fully anonymised version** of your will be shared within Queen Mary University London as part of the submission of the researcher's master's dissertation and upon completion of the masters, may also be available in research journals and also from https://www.nickhatter.com

Under what legal basis are you collecting this information?

- Queen Mary University of London **processes personal data** for research purposes in accordance with the lawful basis of 'public task'.

- Please read Queen Mary's privacy notice for research participants containing **important information about your personal data and your rights** in this respect.

- **If you have any questions** relating to data protection, please contact Queen Mary's Data Protection Officer, Queens' Building, Mile End Road, London, E1 4NS or data-protection@qmul.ac.uk or 020 7882 7596.

What will happen if I want to withdraw from this study?

If you withdraw **within 30 days** of submitting the survey, the pseudonymised research data will be **confidentially destroyed**.

A**fter 30 days** of submitting the survey, the pseudonymised research data will be **confidentially destroyed,** and replaced with a **fully anonymised version,** which will be retained. Research data collected about you can **only** be destroyed **if you withdraw within the 30-day withdrawal window**. If you withdraw **after** this period, the anonymised version of the dataset would have been compiled, and it will no longer be possible to identify your research data specifically for it to be removed or destroyed.

What should I do if I have concerns about this study?

- **If you have any concerns** about the manner in which the study was conducted, in the first instance, please **contact the supervisor(s)** responsible for the study:
  Dr Joanne Wilson - joanne.wilson@qmul.ac.uk
  Tel: +44 (0)20 7882 5555 (ask to speak with Dr Joanne Wilson at the Centre for Psychiatry & Mental Health, Faculty of Dentistry & Medicine)

- **If you have a complaint** which you feel you cannot discuss with the researchers, then you should **contact the Research Ethics Facilitators** by e-mail: research-ethics@qmul.ac.uk.

- When contacting the Research Ethics Facilitators, **please provide details** of the study title, description of the study and QMERC reference number (where possible), the researcher(s) involved, and details of the complaint you wish to make.

Who can I contact if I have any questions about this study?

Student Researcher: Nicholas (Nick) Hatter

Email: ha24392@qmul.ac.uk

Tel: +44 (0)20 3488 0210

You can also contact the researcher by messaging him via Prolific's internal messaging system – see: https://participant-help.prolific.com/en/articles/445028-how-can-i-contact-a-researcher